

What Libraries Already Knew — Why the Record Matters More Than the Book

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A Practical Reflection on Books, Records, and Continuity

Traditional libraries appear to be collections of books.
But in practice, a library was never just a room full of books.

A library held **records about books** — catalogues, accession logs, repair notes, lending records, and classification systems.

The books were the working objects.
The catalogue was the working memory.

Without the catalogue, the books could not be properly managed.
Without the books, the catalogue still described what needed to exist.

The Asymmetry of Loss

Consider two practical situations.

Scenario 1 — Books Lost, Records Survive

If every physical book in a library were destroyed, but the catalogue survived, recovery would still be possible.

Using the catalogue, the library could:

- Identify what titles were held
- Reorder replacement copies

- Accept revised editions if originals were unavailable
- Rebuild the collection gradually

The physical objects would be gone.

But the **identity of the collection** would still be known.

Recovery would be slow, but practical.

Scenario 2 – Books Survive, Records Lost

If every book survived, but the catalogue disappeared, a different problem appears.

The library would still have books.

But it would lose:

- Knowledge of why the books were chosen
- Which editions were important
- The subject structure of the collection
- Relationships between works
- The history of replacement and repair

The library would still have objects.

But it would lose the working knowledge that made those objects useful as a collection.

Why Catalogues Were Treated as Critical

Traditional libraries protected their catalogues with particular care.

Card catalogues, accession registers, and shelf lists were often duplicated or copied because they represented the working memory of the collection. If the catalogue survived, the collection could be rebuilt. If the catalogue was lost, rebuilding became guesswork.

Books could be replaced.

Records had to be preserved.

Libraries Accepted Change as Normal

Traditional libraries expected books to change over time.

A lost or damaged book might be replaced with:

- A later printing
- A revised edition
- A different binding
- A different typeset
- A newer physical format

These changes were not considered failures.

They were normal maintenance.

What mattered was not that every physical copy stayed the same, but that the replacement still served the role described in the record.

Change was allowed — within reasonable limits.

The Shift That Came With Computers

When computers were introduced, the focus changed.

Early digital systems concentrated on:

- Files
- Exact copying
- Bit-level accuracy
- Storage reliability

This made sense at the time.

Digital media were fragile, and data loss was common.

Protecting the file became the priority.

Over time, this led to a subtle shift:

The file began to be treated as the main thing being preserved, while less attention was paid to recording how files changed and were managed over time.

This was a change in emphasis from record-first thinking to object-first thinking.

The Library Lesson for Digital Systems

Digital preservation often focuses on protecting files.

But the library model suggests a broader view.

Files will change.
Formats will change.
Systems will change.

If the history of those changes is recorded clearly, recovery remains possible.

If that history is missing, recovery becomes uncertain.

The important task is not only keeping the object.

It is keeping track of how the object has changed over time.

The Core Insight

Books can be replaced.
Records cannot be guessed.
If the record survives, the collection can be rebuilt.
If the record is lost, the purpose of the collection is lost with it.

Closing Observation

Libraries were never just storage spaces.

They were working systems built to manage change.

They expected loss.
They planned for replacement.
They depended on records to keep the collection usable over time.

With the arrival of computers, attention moved toward protecting individual objects.

It may be worth asking whether, in doing so, we placed too much importance on the object and not enough on the records that make recovery possible.